

PROMPT: TEN WAYS A WOMAN COMES TO SUSPECT HER CLOSEST FRIENDS

2026-09-03. For ChatGPT (Stephen runs it) and for a fresh Fable agent (Claude runs it). Both receive exactly the text below the line and nothing else. Results are saved verbatim beside this file with a disposition table; a scenario counts as considered only when it is in that table. Constraint on the check, not on the generation: we want ten honest candidates, then we rank them.

Context for the operator, not for the model: this replaces the Regent ladder sabotage, which Stephen struck on 2026-09-03 as contrived (a publicly accessible ladder that anyone could have touched). The prior fall on Violet's record is now an innocent, witnessed stumble on the weed-covered slip while she walked backwards talking to someone: bruised all over, swam anyway. It carries no menace and is not to be re-used as the threat. The chosen scenario will become the ground of Violet's genuine locker letter, the thing that made her cut four keys, and the clue Brad's forgery must remove.

You are helping design the inciting fear of a true-crime mystery. Read everything before answering.

The woman. Violet Moore, forty-four, a signwriter in a small coastal city called Havenbay. Fit, sharp, physically confident: she runs up and down ladders all day, swims off the harbour slip most mornings from April to November, eats standing up, keeps her cash in a cookie tin because she distrusts banks, and ranks people's handwriting out loud. She lives alone in a terraced house on Mariner's Row and works from a rented unit behind the fish market, where she keeps a kettle, a radio stuck on one station, and her paint. She is not frail, not nervous, and not given to imagining things. She is the last person in the city who would believe a friend meant her harm, which is why, when she does come to believe it, she has to be right about the evidence and still unable to prove it.

The friends. Four people, her closest, who have keys or near-keys to her life: Liam, who has known her since they were eleven and holds a spare key to her house; Ruby, a nurse, her Tuesday-morning friend, who sits in the car with her with the heater on; Margo, an accountant who does her books and knows her money; Brad, a younger signwriter she taught for seven years on Tuesday nights at her unit, who has a key to the unit. They know her habits: when she swims, which days she works late, where she keeps things, what she eats, which route she walks home. Nobody else in the city knows those things.

What the scenario must do. Design an event, or a small chain of events, that would make this particular woman conclude: one of those four is planning to kill me, I do not know which, and I may be wrong. Each candidate must satisfy all of the following, and you must show how:

1. It happens inside her house, or is aimed so precisely at her private habits that only an intimate could have arranged it. Public places anyone can reach are out. Ladders are out.
2. It needed access or knowledge that only the four have: a key, the location of a spare key, a habit nobody else knows, a routine only they have watched.
3. It was aimed at her specifically, at something she does, not at the house in general.
4. She survives it, ideally unhurt or barely hurt. It is a near miss or a discovered preparation, not an injury. It happens about six weeks before the end of the story's first act, and she keeps working and swimming afterwards.

5. When she inspects it afterwards, she finds a physical detail that says deliberate rather than accident or wear: something unscrewed rather than worn, moved rather than fallen, present that should be absent or absent that should be present. She can hold that detail, photograph it, or keep it.
6. To anyone else, including a competent police officer, the same detail reads as nothing: coincidence, old wiring, a slipped memory, a cat. There is no offence she could report and no suspect she could name. She knows how it would sound.
7. It leaves her frightened enough to make arrangements for her own death without telling any of the four, and to write to them together rather than confront one of them.
8. It must not depend on her being clumsy, forgetful, drunk, or unwell.

What you must not do. Do not name which friend did it. Do not invent a motive. Do not extend the story beyond the event itself. Do not reuse ladders, stairs, or falls. Do not make her a victim of chance.

Output. Ten scenarios, numbered. For each, in this order and in plain prose, no headings inside a scenario:

- The event, in two or three sentences, as it would happen to her.
- The habit or access it exploited, and why only the four could know it.
- What she finds when she looks, the physical detail, and why it says deliberate to her.
- Why the same detail says nothing to anyone else, and what a police officer would say if she reported it.
- What she could keep or photograph, if anything, to leave behind for the four.
- The one thing that would make this scenario fail as story, named honestly.

Then rank all ten, best first, with one sentence per rank saying why it beat the one below it. No scores, no percentages. A forced ranking with no ties.

Write plainly. No em dashes.